

Q I know that “second stage labor” is when my baby is born, but what actually happens during this stage?

While intense, this is possibly the most exciting part of labor since you finally get to meet your baby. Although this stage can be tiring, many women feel encouraged that they can actively start to push their baby out now and that the end is in sight.

The second stage of labor begins when you are fully dilated at 10cm, and ends with the birth of your baby. As the characteristics of transition (see p.213) pass, this signals that the second stage of labor has begun. Along with the waves of contractions, you will feel an unrelenting urge to “bear down” into your perineum (the section of muscle and skin between your anus and your vagina) as your contractions push your baby against the pelvic floor. This bearing down, known as the “Ferguson reflex,” means that

your baby has reached the muscles of your pelvic floor. As the baby presses against nerve receptors there, messages flood your brain to let you know that it’s time to push the baby out. Once your doctor confirms that you are fully dilated, you can do so. Your uterine muscles get some help from your diaphragm and abdominal muscles now, too: the messages to your brain lower your diaphragm and force your abdominal muscles to contract. Your whole amazing body is working to help your baby through your pelvis.

Twists and turns

Your baby’s journey through the birth canal and out into the world involves a series of maneuvers that are known as “the mechanism of labor.” Rather than a straightforward descent down the birth canal and out, in fact, your baby has to make several twists and turns to be able to pass safely through your skeleton. This means that the time it takes for the second stage of your labor to progress is affected both by your baby’s position in the birth canal and just how easy it is for her to turn in the space

THE BIRTH

As your contractions push your baby downward, her body rotates to enable her to emerge through the pelvic opening and out through your vagina.

1 Your baby’s body moves down through your pelvis gradually as your uterus contracts. Your baby’s head is tilted down slightly, toward her chest, and her arms and legs are folded inward, helping her journey through the birth canal.

Intense contractions

During the delivery your contractions are strong and frequent

Placenta The placenta remains attached to the wall of your uterus during the delivery

Pubic bones The hormone relaxin allows the joint that unites your left and right pubic bones to soften during delivery, making your pelvis more flexible

Umbilical cord The umbilical cord stretches out as the baby is delivered

Lowering uterus The top of your uterus lowers as your baby is delivered

Baby’s body The baby’s body faces your spine during delivery

2 “Crowning” is the term used to describe when your baby’s head emerges. The rest of your baby’s body will follow quite quickly as the head is the widest part of your baby and has opened the way for the body to follow.

Baby’s fontanelles The fontanelles and sutures between the skull bones allow some maneuverability

